College football: learn from the past, rank from this season

2026 Week 6 snapshot: October 11, 08:30 UTC. Research completed October 14, 2026.

The selected neural model picks 70.86% of 3,603 FBS winners in 2020–2025. It improves conventional baselines, but does not beat archived sportsbook favorites overall. All matched comparisons and downloadable weights are in REPORT.html.

How historical learning remains preseason agnostic

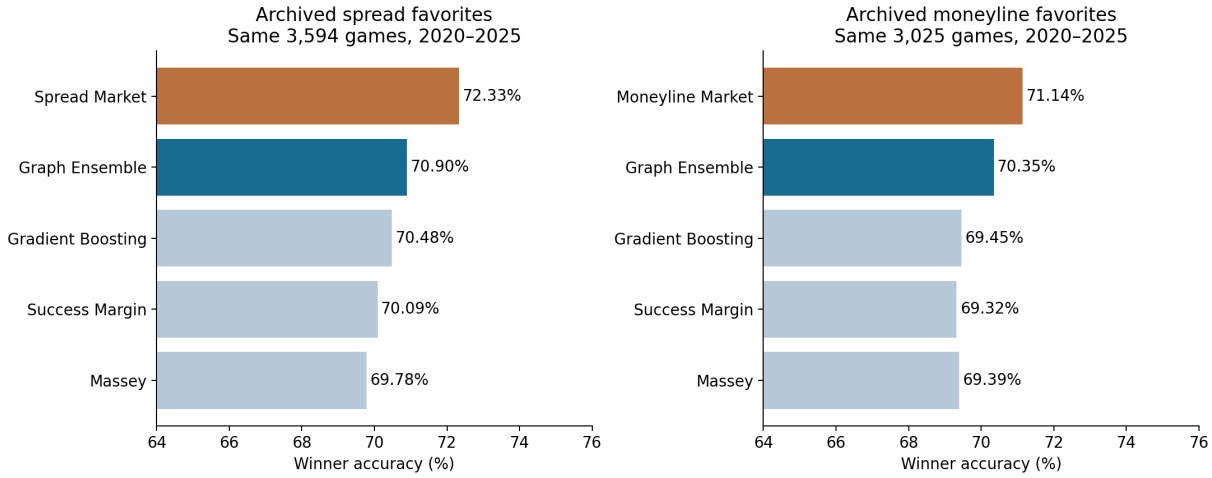
Each historical example contains only that season's statistics available before the game, plus the eventual winner label. Shared network weights learn general relationships. In 2026, features use 2026 games only. No team identity, conference, division, talent rating, preseason prior, or carried team strength enters the network. All teams begin equally.

The selected model averages three seeds of a 64-feature, 8-neuron matchup network and three seeds of a 152-feature, 16-neuron opponent-graph network. Its probability is 75% rich and 25% graph. Neutral rankings sort average win probability against the complete 266-team modeled field.

Matched betting benchmarks, 2020–2025

Benchmark	Games	Neural	Market	Difference
Spread favorites	3594	70.90%	72.33%	-1.43 points
Moneyline favorites	3025	70.35%	71.14%	-0.79 points

Archived quote capture timestamps are unavailable. These prices cannot be certified as opening or closing or as available at the Monday prediction cutoff. This is a prediction comparison, not a profitability test. The later seasons were repeatedly inspected; these are development results, not a pristine holdout. Season-block intervals have only five or six blocks.



2026 Week 6 recommended neural ranking

Rank	Team	Mean neutral win probability
1	Notre Dame	0.9462
2	Miami	0.9352
3	Georgia	0.9298
4	Alabama	0.9270
5	Indiana	0.9191
6	Ohio State	0.9051
7	Utah	0.8983
8	Wake Forest	0.8951
9	LSU	0.8933
10	Texas	0.8905
11	Houston	0.8879
12	BYU	0.8791
13	Missouri	0.8769
14	Iowa	0.8655
15	Mississippi State	0.8653
16	Texas Tech	0.8624
17	Oregon State	0.8598
18	UCLA	0.8577
19	Oregon	0.8441
20	Arizona	0.8440
21	Northwestern	0.8413
22	Ole Miss	0.8386
23	Nebraska	0.8377
24	South Carolina	0.8337
25	Oklahoma State	0.8320

The full rankings for every method, all 415 statistical/neural configurations, and 791 known future-game forecasts are included in the interactive HTML and CSV exports. The CFP has no official Week 6 2026 list; its first release is scheduled for November 3.

Experiments and selection

795 experimental network fits across 264 settings and a convergence check; 240 annual refits; 1,035 total saved fits. Also tested 151 configurations across 22 classical families and supervised logistic regression, boosted trees, and randomized trees.

Experiment	Configurations	Fits / families	What changed
Classical methods	151	22 families	Equal starts; margins, wins, graphs, EPA, success, recency, robust fits
Neural round 1	64	192 network fits	28 features; rank and matchup nets; width, ridge, margin auxiliary loss
Neural round 2	96	288 network fits	64 features; focal loss, four-year training decay, regularization
Neural round 3	32	96 network fits	152 current-season neighbor and two-hop graph features
Neural round 4	72	216 network fits	Past market probabilities as supplemental labels; no live-price input
Convergence check	1	3 additional fits	1500-iteration budget; all three converged, validation got worse

Round 1 trains on 2002–2013 and selects on 2014–2019. Rounds 2–4 train on 2006–2017 and select on 2018–2019. Annual model weights use only earlier seasons. Reusing validation during adaptive experimentation limits generalization claims. Before 2020, yearly results are retrospective architecture hindcasts.

Past market labels did not establish an advantage: the selected market-supervised rank net had 74.18% validation accuracy, falling to 73.67% after a converged longer-training check. Its annual winner accuracy was 70.39%. Validation assigns zero market-supervised weight in the final blend.

Freeze after Week 6, predict remaining games

Method	Games	Accuracy	Log loss
Graph Ensemble	2703	68.87%	0.5882
Rich Neural	2703	68.68%	0.5880
Neural Annual	2703	69.02%	0.5895
Massey	2703	67.87%	0.6000
Success Margin	2703	68.24%	0.5912
Gradient Boosting	2703	68.72%	0.5900

These use the same 2,703 future FBS games with Week 6 features fixed. Later-game market prices may incorporate information obtained after Week 6, so the weekly market comparison is the primary test.

CFP higher-ranked-team benchmark

Cohort	N	Neural	CFP	Difference
At least one team ranked	538	76.02%	73.79%	+2.23 points
Both teams ranked	140	70.00%	58.57%	+11.43 points

Only lists published before kickoff are eligible; at least one team must be ranked. The CFP committee ranks accomplishments for selection, which differs from predicting winners. A positive CFP comparison does not establish a general sportsbook edge.

Selected algorithms: mechanisms, accuracy, Week 6 leaders

Win Percentage

Win fraction, shrunk equally toward .500. No schedule adjustment.

2020–2025: 67.39%, 3603 games, log loss 0.6079. Week 6 top five: Georgia, Indiana, Notre Dame, James Madison, UCLA.

Net Wins

Wins minus losses. No schedule adjustment.

2020–2025: 67.32%, 3603 games, log loss 0.6077. Week 6 top five: Georgia, Indiana, Notre Dame, James Madison, UCLA.

Colley

Solve the schedule Laplacian using wins and losses, with an equal .500 start.

2020–2025: 68.05%, 3603 games, log loss 0.6012. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Indiana, Georgia, Texas Tech, Alabama.

Pythagorean

Points scored and allowed predict expected win fraction; tune the exponent.

2020–2025: 69.30%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5915. Week 6 top five: Miami, New Mexico, Notre Dame, Indiana, Georgia.

Bradley Terry

Fit pairwise win probabilities with equal ridge shrinkage and venue adjustment.

2020–2025: 67.50%, 3603 games, log loss 0.6028. Week 6 top five: Miami, Georgia, Notre Dame, UCLA, Texas Tech.

Massey

Least-squares team strengths explain score margins, opponent quality, and venue.

2020–2025: 69.75%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5760. Week 6 top five: Alabama, Notre Dame, Miami, Georgia, Ohio State.

Capped Margin

Massey fit with capped margins to reduce the influence of blowouts.

2020–2025: 70.00%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5722. Week 6 top five: Alabama, Notre Dame, Miami, Georgia, Ohio State.

Robust Margin

Huber-loss margin fit reduces influence from unusual games.

2020–2025: 69.53%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5733. Week 6 top five: Alabama, Notre Dame, Miami, Georgia, Ohio State.

Recency Margin

Capped margin fit downweights older games within this season.

2020–2025: 69.53%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5749. Week 6 top five: Alabama, Notre Dame, Miami, Georgia, Indiana.

Win Springs

Schedule-adjusted least squares using only the sign of each result.

2020–2025: 66.78%, 3603 games, log loss 0.6158. Week 6 top five: UCLA, Notre Dame, Miami, Alabama, Texas Tech.

Margin Springs

Win springs weighted by margin; large wins pull strengths farther apart.

2020–2025: 69.08%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5856. Week 6 top five: Alabama, UCLA, Notre Dame, Miami, Boise State.

Elo

Sequential game updates from equal zero ratings; tune update speed and margin scaling.

2020–2025: 68.36%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5894. Week 6 top five: Miami, Notre Dame, UCLA, James Madison, Georgia.

Offense Defense Score

Separate schedule-adjusted scoring offense and defense; rank their sum.

2020–2025: 69.66%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5725. Week 6 top five: Alabama, Notre Dame, Miami, Georgia, Ohio State.

Pagerank

A loss-to-winner graph passes credit to teams that beat strong opponents.

2020–2025: 66.47%, 3603 games, log loss 0.6159. Week 6 top five: Georgia, Texas, Alabama, Indiana, Oklahoma.

Keener

Positive eigenvector of nonlinear score shares, normalized by games played.

2020–2025: 69.11%, 3603 games, log loss 0.6021. Week 6 top five: Alabama, Notre Dame, Texas, Georgia, Miami.

Lrmc

A Markov chain with margin-based game transitions and uniform teleportation.

2020–2025: 69.22%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5874. Week 6 top five: Alabama, Georgia, Notre Dame, Miami, Ohio State.

EPA Units

Fit schedule-adjusted offensive and defensive EPA per play, with score fallback.

2020–2025: 67.44%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5951. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Miami, LSU, Georgia, Indiana.

Success Units

Fit schedule-adjusted offensive and defensive success rates, with score fallback.

2020–2025: 67.39%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5958. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Georgia, Ohio State, LSU, Houston.

EPA Margin

Blend adjusted EPA strength and schedule-adjusted score margins.

2020–2025: 69.86%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5712. Week 6 top five: Miami, Notre Dame, Alabama, Georgia, Ohio State.

Success Margin

Blend adjusted success-rate strength and schedule-adjusted score margins.

2020–2025: 70.05%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5682. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Miami, Alabama, Georgia, Ohio State.

EPA Success

Blend adjusted EPA and success-rate strength.

2020–2025: 69.44%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5815. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Georgia, LSU, Miami, Alabama.

Evidence Blend

Blend EPA, success, optional special teams, and margin according to sample size and signal agreement.

2020–2025: 70.30%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5715. Week 6 top five: Miami, Notre Dame, Georgia, Alabama, Ohio State.

Neural Annual

Shared team-strength network on 28 statistics; weights refit on earlier seasons.

2020–2025: 70.19%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5639. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Alabama, Miami, Georgia, Ohio State.

Logistic Features

Supervised logistic regression on numeric team features and venue.

2020–2025: 70.36%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5631. Week 6 top five: Alabama, Notre Dame, Georgia, Miami, Ohio State.

Neural Ensemble

Original shared network blended equally with a feature logistic regression.

2020–2025: 70.30%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5633. Week 6 top five: Alabama, Notre Dame, Miami, Georgia, Ohio State.

Gradient Boosting

Symmetrized histogram gradient-boosted trees on numeric matchup features.

2020–2025: 70.44%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5653. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Miami, Alabama, Georgia, Ohio State.

Extra Trees

Symmetrized extremely randomized trees on numeric matchup features.

2020–2025: 69.97%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5675. Week 6 top five: Miami, Notre Dame, Alabama, Georgia, Ohio State.

Rich Neural

Three-seed 8-neuron antisymmetric matchup network with 64 play and score features.

2020–2025: 70.86%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5618. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Miami, Georgia, Alabama, Indiana.

Rich Ensemble

Validation chose 100% of the rich network; this is an alias, not another learner.

2020–2025: 70.86%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5618. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Miami, Georgia, Alabama, Indiana.

Graph Neural

Three-seed 16-neuron antisymmetric network with 152 current-season graph features.

2020–2025: 70.64%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5651. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Alabama, Miami, Georgia, Indiana.

Graph Ensemble

Recommended: 75% rich-network and 25% opponent-graph-network probabilities.

2020–2025: 70.86%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5617. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Miami, Georgia, Alabama, Indiana.

Market Distilled Neural

16-neuron shared team-strength network trained with past outcomes and past market probabilities as labels; prices are absent at inference.

2020–2025: 70.39%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5621. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Georgia, Alabama, Miami, Indiana.

Market Distilled Ensemble

Validation chose zero market-distilled weight; this is the recommended graph blend again.

2020–2025: 70.86%, 3603 games, log loss 0.5617. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Miami, Georgia, Alabama, Indiana.

Spread Implied Market

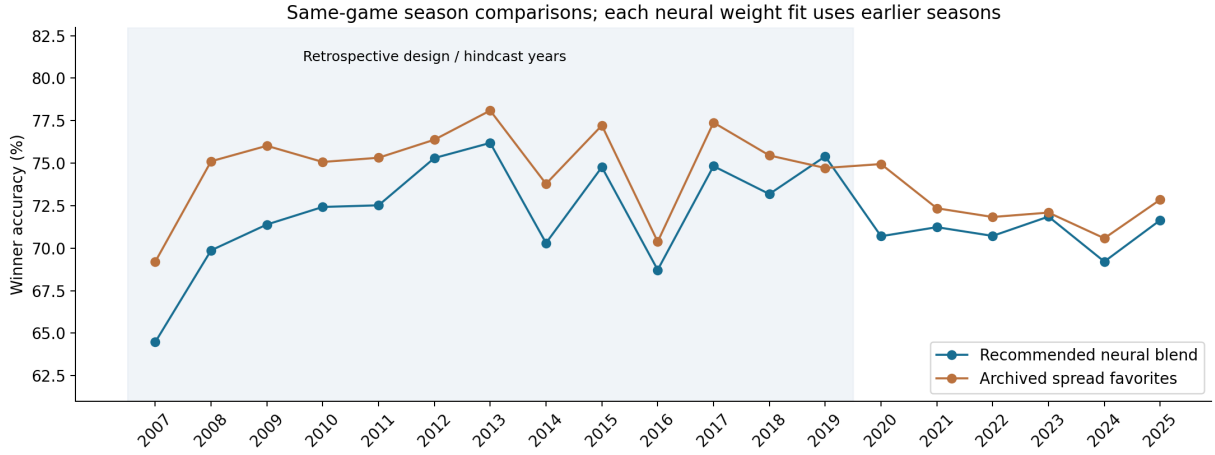
An inferred ranking fitted to archived 2026 spreads through Week 6; not a published sportsbook poll.

2020–2025: —, — games, log loss —. Week 6 top five: Notre Dame, Ohio State, Indiana, Miami, Texas.

Matched annual market comparisons

Year	Benchmark	Games	Neural	Market	Difference
2007	moneyline	348	64.37%	68.68%	-4.31 pp
2007	spread	349	64.47%	69.20%	-4.73 pp
2008	moneyline	229	69.87%	74.67%	-4.80 pp
2008	spread	229	69.87%	75.11%	-5.24 pp
2009	moneyline	364	71.15%	76.24%	-5.08 pp
2009	spread	367	71.39%	76.02%	-4.63 pp
2010	moneyline	358	72.35%	74.86%	-2.51 pp
2010	spread	359	72.42%	75.07%	-2.65 pp
2011	moneyline	393	72.52%	75.19%	-2.67 pp
2011	spread	393	72.52%	75.32%	-2.80 pp
2012	moneyline	417	75.30%	76.62%	-1.32 pp
2012	spread	417	75.30%	76.38%	-1.08 pp
2013	moneyline	420	76.19%	78.10%	-1.90 pp
2013	spread	420	76.19%	78.10%	-1.90 pp
2014	moneyline	431	70.30%	73.55%	-3.25 pp
2014	spread	431	70.30%	73.78%	-3.48 pp
2015	moneyline	428	74.77%	76.99%	-2.22 pp
2015	spread	428	74.77%	77.22%	-2.45 pp
2016	moneyline	422	68.72%	70.38%	-1.66 pp
2016	spread	422	68.72%	70.38%	-1.66 pp
2017	moneyline	427	74.71%	77.40%	-2.69 pp
2017	spread	429	74.83%	77.39%	-2.56 pp
2018	moneyline	440	73.18%	75.00%	-1.82 pp
2018	spread	440	73.18%	75.45%	-2.27 pp
2019	moneyline	439	75.40%	74.60%	+0.80 pp
2019	spread	439	75.40%	74.72%	+0.68 pp
2020	spread	471	70.70%	74.95%	-4.25 pp
2021	moneyline	550	70.18%	70.91%	-0.73 pp

Year	Benchmark	Games	Neural	Market	Difference
2021	spread	584	71.23%	72.35%	-1.11 pp
2022	moneyline	544	69.85%	70.04%	-0.18 pp
2022	spread	584	70.72%	71.83%	-1.11 pp
2023	moneyline	631	71.63%	71.95%	-0.32 pp
2023	spread	636	71.86%	72.09%	-0.24 pp
2024	moneyline	650	68.92%	70.62%	-1.69 pp
2024	spread	656	69.21%	70.58%	-1.37 pp
2025	moneyline	650	71.08%	72.00%	-0.92 pp
2025	spread	663	71.64%	72.85%	-1.21 pp



Limitations and what would test the next improvement

The model lacks timestamped injuries, player availability, lineup changes, and some play-context information. Play coverage is sparse for early archive years and FCS teams. Historical EPA/success fitting vintages may be retrospective. Compact input dates are audited, but this is not a full reconstruction of contemporaneously downloadable data.

Add richer timestamped current-season availability and play context, freeze a protocol prospectively, and compare against timestamped sportsbook prices. More parameters, more epochs, or selecting the best later-season configuration cannot by themselves establish a reliable edge.

These results cover implemented public ranking families, not every known algorithm or private sportsbook, FPI, or SP+ formulas. All source hashes, mathematical implementations, probabilities, weights, and audit exports are saved alongside this report. See METHODS.html for equations and all feature lists, and README.md for commands.